blind to sincerity, now we're here

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blind to sincerity, now we're here

by fishbasketcase

Summary

> “That’s our prince,” Krateros calls out proudly, amid the other soldiers’ cheers and hoots. “The finest example of Kremnoan stoicism and pride. Take note, citizens.”
>
> Phainon wants to scream. Stoicism? Does Krateros know how much his dear liege and pseudo-nephew-figure really wants said stoicism to be obliterated by Phainon’s cock, sometimes multiple times a day? In public, even?

Phainon accidentally gets cursed to read Mydei's mind. This shouldn't be a problem considering how well he knows the man, except. Mydei has many explicit fantasies. Namely, about him. Phainon is in over his head.

Notes

thanks to ao3 reader phaidei4ever, your words made me pop this out in a writing frenzy; i shan't forget your kindness.

this was supposed to be 3k of hentai plot porn, but instead, i like creating contrived reasons to make phainon insane. apologies in advance. please let me know if i'm missing tags, but otherwise, enjoy <3

See the end of the work for more notes

Phainon barely has time to yell as the ground crumbles beneath his feet and he's falling.

A glint of gold flashes in the corner of his vision, and he's reaching out before he realizes Mydei is there, grabbing and yanking him back onto stable territory.

"Snowy!" Comes Tribbie's cry, and he's waving at her to assuage her worries away already, even as his heart still thumps erratically and his feet barely back onto solid ground.

"It's alright, Lady Tribbie," Phainon says as Tribbie flies close, her eyes frightened beacons in the dim lighting. "A fall like that wouldn't have killed me. And besides, Mydeimos is here, nothing will go wrong."

Even in the dark of the ruined temple, Mydei's eyeroll is palpable. "The fall wouldn't kill you, but your lack of attention will." He leans over to flick Phainon's forehead, mouth cracking into a smirk at the ensuing yelp. "Open your eyes, Deliverer."

"My eyes *were* open," Phainon grumbles, but its halfhearted. He's not sure he wants to reveal that he was paying attention just fine, it's more that the attention was placed on Mydei in front carrying Tribios in hand comradely, the two conversing in amused tones. "I can't control the structure of this place, Mydei."

His wrist is still held in a gauntleted hand, and Phainon waits until Mydei is the one who notices and lets go, movement slow and deliberately nonchalant. The tightness of the other man's grip however, is like a brand belying honesty behind Phainon's own covered wrist, and he inwardly smiles at the thought of Mydei's worry for him.

"This temple is definitely a far cry from its golden days, so I don't blame Snowy's misstep." Tribbie smiles, a little sad as the three take in the dilapidated area. "Let's hurry, then. I wouldn't want the whole building to collapse onto us, Snowy, De."

"Do you remember if we're close to the destination?" Mydei inquires, the trio on the move again as they carefully navigate through broken hallways. "A library, you said?"

"Yes," Tribbie says, "It's not as big a library as the one from my old home, but I want to make sure we're not missing potentially valuable information."

Before the black tide finishes this region, is the silent explanation, and Phainon grimly continues his search through the temple on Janusopolis' borders. The ruins are barely holding their shape, creaking every which way with no life around besides the newcomers; it's hard to think this was a place of immense worship, one where Tribios had walked and then led the people away to safety during Era Chrysea.

An excited cry rings throughout the hall and he looks up to see Tribbie point to a specific fallen pillar. At her gestures, Mydei dutifully throws a calculated blow to the pillar, cracking it in a way that it crumbles dustily to reveal a dark doorway, laced with spiderwebs.

"Through here," Tribbie says cheerfully, already flying through, and Mydei and him exchange quick glances of alarm before rushing after her, expressions of caution following

down the stairs and into a dark, musty smelling chamber.

Somehow, candles are found and after lit with a quick motion from Phainon, their eyes adjust to scrolls and tomes every which way, scattered and fallen as if the original inhabitants had been in an immense panic.

“Are we looking for something in particular?” Phainon asks, feeling more than seeing Mydei trail after him in shared curiosity. Mydei had always made remarks of Kremnoans being able to withstand more heat than the average person due to their homeland’s forges; Phainon hadn’t realize that it pertained to their body heat as well, with Mydei’s body feeling like warm sunlight at his back. It made everything else feel colder in response, and Phainon shudders, trying not to curl towards Mydei’s warmth, akin to some desperate sunflower. “Or in general, Lady Tribbie?”

“Anything about Janus, or even Oronyx,” Tribbie says offhandedly, already flitting to a shelf to peer with a close eye. She sneezes at the dust. “Anything that you can think that would help the Flame-Chase, or…”

“Trianne,” Mydei says quietly, and Phainon’s heart sinks at the knowledge.

He turns to meet Mydei’s flame-touched gaze, and smiles. “You take one section of the room, and I the other?”

Mydei merely stares back, and deep down, Phainon thinks about how nice it’d be if he can have insight into the other man’s mind, even if just for a day. Mydei’s actions typically speak louder than words, but Phainon can’t deny that he’s too curious on what Mydei thinks exactly, how he feels, what he truly wants when there are no defenses to manage. Instead, Mydei averts his eyes and gives a noise of assent before taking off to his portion of the chamber. Watching Mydei go off alone, a pang goes through Phainon’s chest at the thought of that: how lonely Mydei seems, even when he says nothing. Phainon can only hope to alleviate some of that loneliness, even if a little.

The idea sticks with Phainon though, even as he rounds a dark corner of a floor-to-ceiling bookcase to peruse the shelves and tables for anything of mote; the more he tries to not notice Mydei’s presence, the more he thinks about him.

He moves a stack of tomes aside, and a dim glow deeper in the shelf catches his eye; curious, Phainon cranes his neck, blowing dust away to reveal a small box compass in the back. The glow is now unmistakable, shining from the box base like moonlight, and without thinking, Phainon reaches out to touch.

The moment his fingers make contact, a sigh seemingly resounds throughout the room, and suddenly, sharp pain strikes his head and Phainon loses all reason as he collapse. His last thought, stupidly enough, is: “Mydei won’t let me hear the end of this.”

He’s already bracing himself to Mydei’s cool judgment when he wakes, apologies on the tip of his tongue— but all he sees the moment he opens his eyes blearily is Mydei’s pale face and stiff lips, something close to terror visible in his eyes. The sight freezes his mouth, and Phainon can only stare back, uncomprehending.

“Phainon,” Mydei whispers, and Phainon wants to kill himself for daring to put that expression on his friend’s face. “Can you— speak?”

Wanting to wipe away that look, Phainon cracks a smile and a joke, heart thumping so loudly. “Of course I can speak. Were you hoping I’d lose my sense of prose? Who else would school you on your lack of poetic sense, Mydei.” At that, Phainon holds himself still— in what he’s now realize to be Mydei’s arms encircling him, holding him upright and feeling so warm and safe as a result— knowing Mydei will shove and gripe at him, their usual dynamic.

Mydei leans, and Phainon continues grinning before— he’s kissed hard, losing all breath and feeling blood vessels burst upon impact. A shaking whimper escapes Mydei’s throat, and that noise shocks Phainon more— a sound so different and just *vulnerable*— even as Mydei continues to press his lips furiously against his, desperate and so, so wanting. Phainon is left gasping as Mydei kisses him on the corner of his mouth, and that’s what makes Phainon really open his eyes—

To see Mydei’s deadpan expression.

“What?” Mydei asks, brows furrowing in what Phainon recognizes as his way of worry. “Did your fall impair your mind?”

“You— you just—“ Phainon sits straight up and flings himself away from Mydei, bumping into a rickety table while he’s at it. He touches his lips, expecting tenderness— and nothing is there, except for its chapped state the moment he journeyed from Okhema this morning.

“I what?” Mydei actually looks concerned now. “Lady Tribios,” he calls out, and within moments, Tribbie appears, looking equally concerned at the scene before her.

“De? Snowy? What happened? Did Snowy fall again?”

“Yes.” Mydei answers flatly as Phainon exclaims, “No!” They stare at each other, Mydei unimpressed as Phainon’s thoughts race.

Lips still tingling with phantom aftershocks, Phainon feels wild because he could’ve sworn he had been kissed within an inch of his life, the passion Mydei exhibiting akin to a lover relieved to find their partner alive and well from certain death. But looking at Mydei’s stiff features, Phainon has to believe that nothing of the sort happened, because he doesn’t think Mydei is capable of recomposing himself so quick, not with the way Phainon imagined the desperation.

The ghost of Mydei’s whimper from Phainon’s psychosis-induced hallucination still echoes in his ears.

“I didn’t fall,” Phainon finally musters, standing up and dusting himself off. “I just had to take a seat.”

Mydei’s judgment is palpable. “Pretty hard seat, wasn’t it.”

“As you know, Mydeimos, I am full of surprises.” And apparently also full of shit, with the way Mydei’s lip curls at his admission.

Tribbie looks between them, her concerned expression not waning. “Maybe we just need to get you out in fresh air, Snowy,” she says, ever the diplomat. “It’s rather dusty in here, after all.”

Phainon stops at that, contrite. “But— what about our research? Did you both find anything of value?”

Mydei shakes his head as Tribbie floats closer to test Phainon’s temperature, her small hand a cool balm to his forehead. “No, there are just old maps and agricultural records in here, nothing about the Titans or Flame-Chase.” She peers closer at Phainon. “Did *you* find something, Snowy?”

He thinks about the suspiciously glowing compass, hidden in the darkest corner behind dusty tomes.

“No.” Phainon smiles. “Not at all.”

His companions both look at him before Tribbie slowly nods, pointing towards the exit and stating their mission is done. He lets the two get ahead of him before swiping at the compass impulsively— no longer glowing— from the shelf and into his pocket.

He’s unsure why he didn’t just show Tribbie the item— out of everyone still alive in this era, she’d probably know exactly what it is— but remembering her tired expression and the memory of Trianne’s condition, Phainon can’t bring himself to bother her further. He seems fine now, besides; perhaps the stress is getting to him, and that's plausible enough.

Mydei, however, does not take Phainon’s silent reasonings as plausible enough, because the moment they reach Okhema and bid goodbye to Tribbie, he turns to Phainon and grits out, “Follow me. Now.”

Phainon wearily does, the compass burning a hole in his pocket as if reminding him of his deception.

They duck in a lone alcove near Marmoreal Palace, and Phainon readies himself to make up whatever excuse is necessary to throw Mydei off his tail because the likelihood of Phainon just having some strange mind episode during a mission is embarrassing to consider— when Mydei spins and grasp his wrist. The grip isn’t tight or even a cage, but the feelings of desperate worry again washes through Phainon as he stares dumbly at Mydei.

“You… you fell so quietly,” Mydei says, and his tone is intense as his eyes lit up Phainon’s soul. “I almost didn’t notice.”

Phainon’s throat is dry as he tracks the way Mydei bites his lips, a tic Phainon knows when Mydei is feeling pain and not wanting to admit it. “But you did notice.”

“Then what are you hiding, Phainon.”

The sound of his spoken name nearly makes him spill everything on the spot, but the sudden image of a slim, gaunt-looking man with pale hair and eyes flash through his mind, clean as his own memories. The man, laying prone on a cot, smiles and holds onto a familiar red-marked hand, saying, *"It's alright, Mydei. I'll be alright."*

Mydei sits facing him, allowing his hand to be held even though he doesn't squeeze back. There are blood splatters over his body, and along with the stony expression he holds, Phainon thinks he's seeing a war god from legend, back from a gory duel. The silent tears tracking down Mydei's face is what stops the myth and Phainon's heart, as Mydei whispers in the most even tone, *"Liar."*

He blinks and it's a clean, blood splatter-free Mydei in front of him, eyes sharp.

"What are you hiding?" Mydei asks again, and Phainon shakes his head, trying to reassure and banish the memory in equal regard— because it is, it has to be a memory, *Mydei's memory*— from mind.

"Nothing," Phainon says, "There's nothing wrong. I'm alright." He winces as Mydei frowns, the image superimposed by past Mydei's colder look. "I promise, Mydei. I wouldn't jeopardize the Flame-Chase if something's wrong, I swear."

"The Flame-Chase is the least of it," Mydei says. "What would this city do without their Deliverer? Just shut down?"

"What would I do without you?" Phainon's mind Mydei says instead, shockingly straightforward and even selfish; Phainon's breath catches at the open look in this Mydei's eyes, unguarded and waiting.

The real Mydei looks and says nothing of the sort, but Phainon reaches out to hold back anyway, taking in Mydei's widening eyes and feeling reassured in the truth of what he's seeing in reality and mind matching in sentiment. Mydei's wrist fits perfectly in Phainon's hand, the bones almost fragile thin despite the absolute carnage he's seen these limbs wrought.

"I'm alright," Phainon says, with much feeling. Then he jerks Mydei close, taking satisfaction in Mydei's surprised catch of breath. "Let me show you then, if you still don't believe me."

He's the one kissing Mydei this time, but just as desperate and longingly, as if they'd both been waiting forever for this moment. Maybe forever is true, with the way Mydei makes that *whimper* again, igniting Phainon's blood like nothing else as he bites Mydei's mouth open. It's a struggle because Mydei won't just take him without a fight, and it's so, so good, the way they clash and dance here, too.

"Deliverer," Mydei sighs, once they break apart to breathe, and his eyes are blown dark. Phainon just has to back him into the alcove wall, has to pin his perfect wrists down, has to kick apart his legs and crowd close in, has to put his hands around those troublesome pants and greaves and just yank it all down, has to—

Reassure an increasingly worried-looking Mydei that his brain isn't impaired and that Phainon is fine, totally fine.

He smiles weakly and pats Mydei's wrist, phantom sensation of lips and teeth still tingling across his skin; it's a struggle to not get cross-eyed with his actual sight and the images in his mind, both superimposed with each other like hazy mirages. "I'm alright, Mydei. So for now, let's part ways. I have to take care of a few things before tomorrow, after all."

Mydei's wrist slides out of his grasp as Phainon finally convinces him to go, giving one last lingering look behind him. Phainon watches him go before sagging his back to the alcove, mind overloading with new information and emotions.

Whatever that compass did, it seems to have grant Phainon the ability to read minds.

Specifically, Mydei's mind. How does he know this, with utmost certainty? Three solid reasons.

1) Phainon doesn't know nor recognize that sickly man from his memory— a sickly man who is more than likely dead, considering memory Mydei's cold grief and reality Mydei's own worry towards Phainon's perceived condition— and he's not imaginative enough to come up with a whole different person in the limited free time he has.

2) Even when Tribios placed her hand on him, Phainon was not pelted with her feelings and memory, even when her worry was clear as day and they were surrounded by an ancient past in that ruined temple.

And 3) He does *not* know what Mydei sounds or taste like in an intimate capacity, and only gained the knowledge after being touched and touching the man approximately thrice.

There are still holes to his theory, he'll admit, but this is all he has that makes the most sense.

Phainon drags a hand down his face, suddenly exhausted and frayed at the seams.

The sheer shock of Mydei's desire is what gets him. Is that what Mydei really thinks and wants? Of Phainon? In that capacity? On the daily? And so readily? With that outwardly reserved and noble expression? Or…

The thought of the sickly man again— someone Mydei seemed to have cared deeply for— brings a myriad of conflicting feelings: grief for Mydei's loss, and curiosity of the people he knew before Phainon and their exact significance— well. It more than likely explains Mydei's tendencies to walk alone. Phainon swallows at the thought, thinking about how he wasn't the first friend Mydei had. It shouldn't matter, but Phainon has to worry if Mydei's needing more companionship than he'd ever ask for, perhaps that being why it's translated into him having such vivid, intimate daydreams.

Phainon is his closest friend now, after all. That fact, he's certain of.

However… Mydei hadn't asked for his mind to be read. In public, he's polite and well-meaning, professional, even, and within close company, he has a wry sense of humor. With

Phainon, there's competition and introspection. But none of that desperation and intimate ferocity in sight, only what Phainon can see in mind.

Besides, the fantasies Mydei imagined were rather… not childish, but not as explicit as Phainon was expecting— not that he was expecting anything! Just kisses and some light petting. Rather innocent, and honestly appropriate in the grand scheme of working adult fantasies towards friends and colleagues.

Phainon nods to himself as he gets up and dust his knees. Mydei clearly desires close relationships, and with how heavy and lonely their duties are— it makes sense that his fantasies are more on the intense side.

This will not be a problem, Phainon'll make sure of it. Hopefully the effects from the mysterious compass will wear off soon, and along with the rather calm nature of Mydei's persona, well, Phainon's sure he'll be able to handle it without anyone noticing too close.

He needs to be a good friend and look out for Mydei, in any way he's able.

His lips still sting pleasantly from imagination Mydei's sweet, knowing smile.

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"I'm not into exhibitionism," Mydei says flatly, even as Phainon bends him over against the ledge high up and overseeing the marketplace.

"Maybe I am," Phainon offers graciously, even as he pulls Mydei's robe to a side and starts on his pants. "You on the other hand, well, I suppose you're an enigma to us all." He can't stop the grin gracing his lips as Mydei hisses when Phainon's hand wraps around his hardening length. Slick runs down his hand predictably, and Phainon *tsks,* shaking his head. "Not into exhibitionism, didn't you say?"

"Shut up," Mydei says, charmingly predictable, and he ruts into Phainon's palm with a desperate and quiet groan. "You're the one that just…"

"Just what, Mydeimos?" Phainon kisses his ear sweetly, even as his grip turns bruising and nearly prompting a yelp from Mydei. "I didn't start this, you know. I just wanted to help out your troubles."

"The only trouble here is you." Mydei mutters, before trying to reach down and take care of his problem. He makes a frustrated noise when Phainon bats his hand away, shoulders tensing up to his ears almost pathetically if Phainon didn't think it so cute. "Let me touch."

"You can keep your hands on the ledge, instead," Phainon says. "I'll do the work for us both. You have to look natural, Mydei, in case somebody glances up and sees the crowned prince of Castrum Kremnos lounging up here."

Mydei actually *whines* at that, and the blood rushing to Phainon's cock makes him lightheaded at the sound.

“Then, in me—“ Mydei says, voice rough. He turns to peer at Phainon, the profile of his nose, lips, and long lashes striking and unfairly beautiful; tears seem to bead at the edge of his sunset eyes, and Phainon stares, entranced. “In me, Deliverer.”

"In you?" Phainon's mouth is dry, the sight before him the only thing satiating thirst. He releases Mydei, excitement building more and more at the clear desperate restraint his friend exhibits, shaking with it. "Do you need my fingers?" He presses his hands to Mydei's hips, hard enough to bruise. "My mouth?" He bites at Mydei's neck, panting against flushed skin. "Or..."

"Yes," Mydei says, trying to sound angry but coming off impatient instead. What a spoiled prince. "I need—“

"—you to go see Aglaea, she's needing help with the council."

Phainon stares up at Mydei's peerless and calm face, and has to hold back the urge to accuse of him many, many things.

"Ye-*es?"* Phainon croaks out, wincing at the frog-like tone, and Mydei frowns more. "Yes, yes," he rushes to say, breaking away from Mydei's hold on the shoulder. "I'll get to it right now."

"You don't even know the assignment," Mydei says, exasperated, and Phainon wants to start laughing like a loon.

At this point, the only thing he'll know is how many sex scenarios Mydei comes up with.

“It’s alright, I’ll ask Aglaea directly,” Phainon says, blinking away afterimages of a teary Mydei just to see the real deal coolly looking back. He runs away like a coward, knowing he’s being obvious about it but not knowing what else to do.

He, unfortunately, may be in over his head with this situation.

It’s barely been day two of his current predicament, but he’s never realized how much he and Mydei *touch* each other on the regular when in orbit.

And until now, he’s never known the amount of absolutely filthy fantasies the last prince of Castrum Kremnos was harboring, all on his lonesome.

Morning breakfast, and he clasps a comradely hand on Mydei’s arm as he usually does: suddenly, he’s shoving Mydei and spreading his legs wide to the floor like a brute, fucking him so sloppily he’d be embarrassed by how frantic he’s being if Mydei himself isn’t moaning and egging him on.

They walk through the Garden of Life to give Hyacine updates, and Mydei inevitably gives Phainon a nudge at one of his remarks: Mydei’s pulling him into the stair recess with the two chairs, and proceeding to give Phainon the slowest, wettest ride of his life, abs and arms tensing as he leans back on Phainon’s knees to do his work while Phainon lounges like some hedonistic king, mouth panting at the sight.

Phainon decides to tease the little chimeras with food, Mydei bops him for his antics: Phainon's slinging Mydei's leg over a shoulder as he fucks in deep, holding down a stray pretty wrist as he leans in close to whisper, "Want me to fill you up?" Mydei bites his lip, looking rather bullied and saying nothing as Phainon smiles back and rubs the man's heaving chest, hand trailing down to linger over Mydei's stomach. "What about here, Mydeimos? I can fill you full, all you need to do is ask."

They have to exchange paperwork as per Castorice's request and Phainon's fingers touch Mydei's briefly as he passes the slips: he's being pushed into a corner, back hitting the wall hard as Mydei advances with a simmering look in eye. Phainon takes in a sharp breath as Mydei drops hard to his knees in front of him, the desire to scold Mydei's harsh treatment of his body at odds with the way his blood thrums at Mydei deftly unbuckling his pants and swallowing him down to the choking root.

The most damning is when they did their daily spar to show the Kremnoan Detachment soldiers examples. Phainon's grinning as he disarms Mydei in hand to hand, a clever maneuver as he pins Mydei's arm behind his back with a knee pressed firm. He tells Mydei, "I'm going to show them how it's done", and is suddenly blindsided with a version of himself saying, "I'm going to show them how to make you *scream",* as his fingers slither down to stretch Mydei, the man himself spitting and hissing even as his hole yields to Phainon's administrations so well.

Mydei manages to buck him off in his lapse of sanity, and with quick movement, knocks Phainon on his back and crouches over him, a ready fist centimeters from Phainon's face. The hollering around has Phainon tense further, frustrated at the audience for seeing Mydei like this— but they're only seeing a victory brawl, not him showing hole to Aquila with daydream Phainon as a willing and enthusiastic participant.

"Show them, you say?" Mydei huffs, pleased by his turnaround, as imaginary Mydei is breaking apart on Phainon's cock from behind, no longer struggling, just taking what he's given.

"That's our prince," Krateros calls out proudly, amid the other soldiers' cheers and hoots. "The finest example of Kremnoan stoicism and pride. Take note, citizens."

Phainon wants to scream. Stoicism? Does Krateros know how much his dear liege and pseudo-nephew-figure really wants said stoicism to be obliterated by Phainon's cock, sometimes multiple times a day? In public, even?

Though, looking into Mydei's cool expression, Phainon will grudgingly concede to everyone's ignorance, even as he's pelted with another image of Mydei sucking on his fingers and whimpering around them.

The urge to accuse Mydei of exhibitionism is strong, because for a man who said in his fantasies that it's not his kink— well, there sure are a lot of scenarios that involve public settings, indecency, and just a general audience around. The idea of people watching in those daydreams— irritation surges in Phainon at the thought. It doesn't help on how much Mydei's own people in reality also seem to love him dearly— *as they should* — surrounding him and being rather touchy in a reverent way.

There's a particular soldier, one who's been in the Detachment for as long as Mydei has been, who's extra friendly. Phainon doesn't know his name, but knows that he likes to clap a hand on Mydei's impressive bicep, rub it a bit as he chatters his admiration.

Phainon watches him go after he finishes what he wanted to say to his prince.

"You have an issue with one of my soldiers, Deliverer?"

Jumping at the sudden question, Phaion turns to look at an unimpressed Mydei. "What? No!"

Mydei raises an eyebrow. "Then what's the reason for staring after him?" A thought seems to occur to him. "Do you, perchance," Mydei says carefully, "have… feelings for him? It will not work out. For you, that is."

Phainon can barely believe his ears. "I don't have *feelings* for him? I don't even know him!" He pauses, mind racing. "Do you… I mean, he's been with your Detachment since the beginning, is it fair to infer that *you* have feelings?" The thought sours his mood, thinking about this familiar soldier, one he remembers from their first meeting in Okhema. It wouldn't be out of the question for Mydei to be… to choose someone, familiar and comfortable.

He's done it before.

Mydei rolls his eyes. "I respect my people's attentions, but I do not wish to return them in any capacity more than duty. I'm too busy, along with having priorities that differ from the health of any intimate relationship. And besides, when I said it will not work out for you— it wouldn't for me, either."

"…Why is that?"

"He obviously has his own lover," Mydei says, as if that's fact. Maybe it is, and Phainon's too blind. "I wouldn't disrespect that."

So, Mydei respects attention, but doesn't touch back. And therefore, dreams up the most crazily hottest fantasy scenarios, as a result.

Right. *Right.* Phainon wants to put his head in between his knees to breathe properly.

Mydei being a person of constant contradiction— so reserved on the surface yet filled with such intense desires below— is an effective measure to drive Phainon insane. The fantasies might calm down if Mydei just touch and get touched more, Phainon thinks. Mydei is clearly restrained, if not outright repressed.

The thought riles Phainon, more than he'd like to admit.

It's barely noon.

It's the blasted compass, Phainon thinks, hiding in the garden atop Marmoreal Palace. He has the item out on a ledge, glaring at it as he tries to examine any plausible clue dictating its properties on parts. If he can figure out the solution, things will return back to normal, and Mydei will be none the wiser about Phainon's predicament.

“Phainon?”

He freezes at the sound of his name, but relaxes the moment he sees Aglaea being the speaker. He stops in place again as Tribios appears behind her, face bright and inquisitive. As if to add further insult to injury, the Trailblazer is *also* with them, looking far too relaxed and meandering for the turmoil in his mind at the situation.

It’s too late to hide the compass, as both demigods and Stelle zero on his body angled towards it.

“It’s so nice to see you,” Phainon reacts quickly, plastering a benevolent smile on his face as he ducks in front of the compass to hide from their view. “Is there something you need of me?”

Aglaea’s eyes, however blind she says, seems to see him to the soul. “I seem to recall asking Mydeimos to relay to you my need of assistance.”

Phainon’s heart sinks because in his haste to escape Mydei’s attention, he’d totally forgotten the man’s news. “I am so sorry—“

“No worries,” Aglaea says, raising a hand to quell Phainon’s obvious panic. “My teacher and Lady Stelle were of great aid. A solution was found. But for you—“ Her eyes slid to the placement of the compass behind Phainon’s back, “— it appears you may be the one in need of assistance, Deliverer.”

“What is it, Snowy?” Tribbie comes close, small hand reaching out to grasp at his sleeve. “You’ve been a bit odd ever since our mission yesterday. Did something happen?”

Stelle says nothing, far too intent on the scene; she gives a thumbs up, however, and that somehow prompts Phainon to sigh and reveal the compass.

“I… I encountered this yesterday, in the library at the ruined temple,” Phainon say, haltingly, as both demigods peer close at the item. “I’m in no pain nor am I experiencing suffering. It’s why I didn’t want to bother you with inquiry of the nature of this compass, Lady Tribbie, as you’ve had so much on your mind of late.” Well, he is suffering, but no one really needs to know just what kind.

“Snowy,” Tribbie chides lightly, and she tugs again at his sleeve. “You’re someone I care about, and you have much on your plate as well. Why wouldn’t I try to help, if to lighten your burden a little? You’d do the same for me.”

“But you’re experiencing effects.” Aglaea cuts to the chase, and cowed, he nods.

“…Yes. It’s nothing I can’t handle.” Yeah, right. He’s just going slightly insane about his greatest rival and friend, is all. Just another day in the life of Phainon of Aedes Elysiae. “Do you know what this item is, exactly?”

At Tribbie’s outstretched reach, he hesitates before depositing the compass in her hands, afraid that she’d be afflicted with the same curse.

Nothing of the sort happens as she examines the item, turning it whichever way.

“Old,” Tribbie murmurs, holding it up for Aglaea’s perusal. “I’m sure this was created before I ascended, Snowy. Long before.”

“It’s just a compass,” Aglaea says, stroking a fine finger over the sides of the box. “From when Janus was the main Coreflame holder?”

“Yes,” Tribbie nods, but then pauses, biting her finger in concentration. “There are… old folklore about Janus’ powers, when they first appeared in the world.”

“Isn’t Janus the Titan of pathways?” Stelle chips in, exercising her newfound knowledge of their world. “What other powers can the Titan have if not show passages and directions?”

“They’re also one of the Titans of fate.” Phainon’s throat is dry as his mind works through the information. “Definer of rules and destiny, along with being the closest to humanity.”

Tribbie nods again. “They’re not recorded anywhere anymore, but old archives used to make mention of Janus’ desire to help direct humanity in whatever path deemed fit. Splitting into many pieces is a core ability of the Titan, but in this case, they were able to put pieces of their power in items to guide people to their destinations.”

“Like a compass.” Stelle has the box now, and shakes it.

“Sure, but these items didn’t just direct towards tangible paths,” Tribbie says. “They directed people to destiny, to desires, to potential ruin. Janus… while a Titan that guided humanity through pathways, Talanton’s laws made this aid a double-edged blade.”

“So, what, this compass can just zap you towards whatever you’re wanting?” Stelle asks, yellow eyes flickering between the item and Phainon. “Is that a bad thing, really?”

“The compass can be backhanded in itself, perhaps even as a test for humanity,” Aglaea murmurs. She looks thoughtfully at the item in question. “What you want may not be what you need. That can push most people to ruin. I’m not surprised if that’s a reason why not many more of these items have been found. Either their powers are gone, used, or lost, or Janus only made a select few in an attempt to help before it became too chaotic.”

What you want may not be what you need.

Phainon had wanted a glimpse into Mydei’s mind, curious on what the other man really thought and wanted.

How did that minor wish translate to a magical compass in exposing Phainon to Mydei’s inner workings? What is the purpose of this direction? Destiny? In what, expanding his imagination on what Mydeimos looks like in pleasure? Or in helping Mydei find companionship, to mitigate his obvious loneliness?

He’s not sure what possibility makes him feel more conflicted.

Will this… ruin them?

He shakes his head. No. He can't let it. He can't let his own stupid impulse trap the two of them like this. Mydei deserves his own peace of mind and good friendships, and Phainon…

"Sounds like a curio," Stelle is saying, and he tunes in to listen. She seems to derive great pleasure in shaking a Titan's vessel of power like a toy. "I've encountered things like that. They grant an effect, sometimes good, sometimes bad, sometimes a mixed bag in between. All you gotta do is ride it out. It has to end sometime. And besides…" She tosses the compass to Phainon, and he narrowly drops it, not expecting the throw. She grins. "Sometimes the effects may seem bad at first, but the outcome is worth it in the end."

An outcome worth it in the end? Phainon thinks, as he goes about his day on auto-pilot, after their conversation. What outcome would be worth viewing Mydei's many sex fantasies, of which the man is unaware of the invasion of his own privacy?

And it's not that Phainon is a prude or anti-sex. They're all grown adults with their own intimate histories, and Titans know the amount of things he's seen in the public baths in passing.

The things he's seen Mydei do in the past—

Phainon banishes that thought, and proceeds to suffer through dinner.

"Come on," Phainon cajoles, pushing a piece of honeycake towards Mydei's mouth. "Another bite, Mydeimos."

Mydei purses his lips, turning away, but Phainon shifts his face back with a gentle hand under his chin. Glowering, he does indeed take a bite, making Phainon's heart pump at the sensation of Mydei's lips wrapping around the spoon.

"There," he says, voice hoarse. "That wasn't so bad now, was it. You need to eat."

"And what about you?" Mydei asks flatly, but Phainon can see he's at his wit's end with the way restrained energy makes his body tremble. "You need to eat, too."

Phainon has to laugh. "Oh, I will." He pats Mydei's stomach before pushing the man to sit more firm on his cock, both of them barely holding in their groans. Hugging Mydei closer by plastering to his back, Phainon reaches out to the table and slices more cake, feeling Mydei tense at seeing the spoon rise. "Come on, one more."

Mydei squeezes down on him, the oil spilling out of his hole as he tries to rise again but sinks back with a hard breath at Phainon's insistent palm. "I…" Mydei grits his teeth and hangs his head, and it just makes Phainon more excited, to see this kind of cute struggle. "I'm full."

Phainon pets his stomach before he *really* pushes down, making them both feel the bump behind those firm muscles. Mydei's panting now, wet gasps that sound so delightful to Phainon's ears. "One more, Mydei. Just one."

A beat, and then, stiffly, Mydei leans to take the last spoonful, Phainon waiting him out as he chews and swallows. "There," Mydei finally says, "I'm done."

Phainon places his spoon down delicately…before proceeding to rise in quick motion to scoot all the dishware and utensils off the table, bending Mydei over the now emptier space.

“But I’m not done,” Phainon tells him, stroking a hand down Mydei’s flank, the man himself looking back, so needy on Phainon’s cock as he moves his hips in half-aborted motions. The sight has Phainon lean in close with a smile. “My turn to eat.”

“Is the soup too spicy for your palate, Deliverer?” Mydei asks, and Phainon has to blink at the question and the image of gasping Mydei away, as the real one peels a thigh from his just to lean and bring back a cup of water.

“Soup?” Phainon says dumbly, feeling his cock twitch with aftershocks of warmth surrounding it in the daydream.

“Yes…” Mydei says slowly, truly concerned now. “The one in front of you. You’re rather red.”

And who’s fault is it, Phainon wants to fume. Who in the world has the quick-fire audacity to come up with a whole food-sex scene during dinner in public? With no visible shame or reaction, nonetheless? Mydeimos of Castrum Kremnos, apparently, as the man in question dutifully switches out Phainon’s supposedly spicy soup for some mild rice and meat.

But seeing the worried furrow in Mydei’s brow, Phainon deflates because at the end of the day, he is the one that chose his usual spot right next to Mydei in the hall.

Mydei’s thigh touches his again, and the mind flash of Phainon pounding the ever-living lights out of Mydei on the table has Phainon clenching his fists in his lap because how the hell is he going to survive the baths, at this rate?!

Phainon’s dread of bath time is at odds with his joy in it; sharing baths with trusted comrades and making sure no black tide rot remains is his way to de-stress— he hadn’t realized this area would be impacted by his new curse, too. Silently mourning for any semblance of peace in the baths tonight, Phainon takes a breath and braves the storm.

Yet, to his immense and incredulous surprise… no perverted scenes came along.

Mydei is calm, regal as always in the bath as he promptly washes alongside the other heirs. The occasional bump and poke doesn’t bring forth scenes of debauchery for Phainon. At one point, Phainon even throws a friendly arm around Mydei’s naked shoulders under the guise of reminiscing on past battles— all to see what Mydei imagined.

No visible images comes forth, odd enough, but the emotions of calming ease is overpowering, leading Phainon to think that Mydei feels too comfortable and mindful of the other heirs to think anything scandalous.

Or maybe his curse wore off, as Stelle’s comparison to curios indicates?

Mindlessly, he squeezes the back of Mydei’s neck, and his friend jumps a little; a flash of Phainon holding Mydei down by the back of his neck as he fucks the other man raw has him

re-evaluating his theory pretty quickly.

“Stop touching me,” Mydei says, breaking away along with clearing Phainon’s mind.

“What,” Phainon laughs, his heart still thrumming at the vividest image in the bath yet tonight. “Hiding something, Mydeimos?”

“I should be asking you that,” Mydei grumps, but he’s swiftly climbing out of the bath, leaving Phainon behind, flabbergasted.

Does Mydei know about his curse? No, he shouldn’t, since Phainon hadn’t revealed the exact nature of the issue to anyone. Then maybe…

Memories about black tide corruption arises, of it spreading steadily and taking away everyone he loves— that’s what prompts Phainon to be outside of Mydei’s space two hours later, waiting.

“Let’s take a bath,” Phainon is already saying, after Mydei answers his knocks. “Come on, Mydei.”

“We just took one,” Mydei says, and for some reason, he’s the one looking flush now; the color is barely perceptible on his high cheekbones, but Phainon’s always been observant.

His anxiety about potential rot corrupting his friend arises again, and Phainon smiles flatly. “Come on. Another time. For old time’s sake. We didn’t take one yesterday together, after all.”

Mydei sighs. “What do you mean for old time’s sake? We usually take two anyway on the daily, no thanks to your wheedling.” But his eyes soften, as if understanding where Phainon’s need for more baths than the norm comes from. “Fine. Let me get my oils.”

He turns to go, and overjoyed, Phainon reaches out to pat his back out of instinct. The moment his hand touches that bare skin, a memory flashes through his mind— not a daydream— of Mydei, merely an hour after their first bath, in this room, biting onto what Phainon shockingly realizes to be his own forgotten shirt from one late night spar, years ago.

He knows it’s his own shirt— the familiar white linen now worn to an aged cream with trailing threads, a testament to how much he’s fought and lived in it before it went missing. Phainon can still see the tear in the side where Mydei had swiped at him with his sharp gauntlet in their earlier days, catching on the airy material and ripping it from Phainon’s person. Mydei had apologized, expression of sincerity odd with Phainon’s then perception of him, but Phainon merely laughed and shook it off, throwing the shirt aside just so he can fight again, hand to hand. He hadn’t realized the innocuous article had been picked up and hidden by none other than the one that inflicted the tear.

Mydei’s mouth is damp, flush more intense and sweet on his face as his free hand works his cock, already leaking so much at the tip. Moaning, Mydei swipes through the wetness just to bring his hand behind, working two fingers in his ass as he curls tighter on the bed; the shirt

is still in his grasp, and he turns his head just to inhale it deeply, even though Phainon's absolutely sure the original smell should be faded by now.

Mydei pulls away from his touch, heading deeper into his space to grab the mentioned oils, and leaving Phainon feeling like his brain's been kicked in by Little Ica.

He wonders, if he steps further into the room, if the musky scent of what happened barely an hour before will still be lingering in the air. If his old shirt smells like Mydei now, after so many years.

But Mydei returns and pushes him out, the two ending back in the baths but this time alone at the late hour.

Phainon can barely look at his companion as they settle in the bathwater, mind burning by what he witnessed unwittingly. It's one thing to deal with daydreams, but a real and recent memory just… highlight things in a way he's not sure how to consider. It just made things more tangible, and he shivers at the thought.

"Quiet tonight, aren't you," Mydei observes, as he ties up his hair into a neat ponytail. Stray strands still escapes, framing his usually sharp face into something softer.

Phainon's throat is so dry.

What is Mydei thinking right now, with no one else around? Where they're both naked, together, in the baths?

"It's just—" Phainon moistens his lips, averting his eyes at how bare Mydei's neck is, now that his hair is up. A bead of water from the baths rolls slowly down Mydei's ample chest, circling around a dusky nipple. "I thought some nights without excessive chatter would be something you'd enjoy. Don't tell me you miss my dulcet tones already."

"A quiet night is all well and good," Mydei says, raising a fine eyebrow. "But you've been... odd, as of late." His elbow touches Phainon's— and Phainon has the split, panicky realization of how close they're sitting in the baths— when Mydei's imaginary self says, "I'd miss your voice, yes."

No hint of lust. Only exasperated fondness.

Phainon is reminded how bare they both are when Mydei leans away to start administering oils through the tips of his hair, leaving coolness behind at Phainon's elbow.

"I'm fine, I promise," he says automatically. "Just... a lot has been going through my mind recently." Understatement of the era. "You know, you don't have to indulge in my bath habits, right?"

Mydei leans back, and Phainon's exposed to a long arch of bare, muscled skin, flushed light pink in the baths and highlighting the red marks stark. "It's not indulging you."

"What, you like baths then?" Phainon tries to chuckle. "No one will judge you if that's the case, considering how important bathing is to the culture."

"I don't like baths, either, Deliverer." That has Phainon curious enough to casually lean back to touch elbows, wanting to see the meaning in the statement.

No intimate images, only... feelings. An unease Mydei feels that Phainon sees is directed at the water. The feeling reminds him offhandedly of when Mydei and his Detachment first arrived in Okhema, and after a period of spars, negotiations, and gradual understanding, Phainon had invited Mydei to the baths only to be turned away. He wore the man down eventually, of course, especially after seeing black tide corruption on Mydei's skin after a harrowing campaign, but... he can never quite forget the stiff way Mydei blinked, once confronted with Marmoreal Palace's large, open baths.

The feelings of unease changes as Mydei turns to look at Phainon, and all he can feel now from the other man's thoughts are reassurance and calm. As if... he sees a daydream of himself, holding onto Mydei's wrist, the water splashing gently between them, and Mydei can only stare back, feelings of safety and shy contentment clear as Kephale's light.

Instinctively, Phainon does as his daydream self does— holds onto Mydei's wrist, feeling the fine bones creak in his grip at Mydei's surprise.

"Deliverer...?" Mydei asks, tone low, eyes like smoldering embers.

"Mydei," Phainon returns and then stops, unsure on what to say.

Mydei stares back, and Phainon gets a flash of the man leaning over to kiss him—

Before Mydei does just that.

Phainon's mouth opens in shock at the reality— a desperate low noise escapes Mydei's throat, causing his blood to *sing*— and Mydei presses closer, not aggressive but just out of sheer desire to mesh with Phainon and taste.

He's reminded so strongly of the first time he received the cursed visions, of Mydei's relief at seeing Phainon's well-being and kissing him in the fantasy— the feeling of *waiting* and *forever* and *finally* shining through so bright, despite it never being real in the first place.

Mydei moans, the sound almost terrifyingly loud in the empty baths, and Phainon just chases that noise like a hound, biting and kissing and giving as good as he’s able. He tangles a hand in Mydei’s hair, freeing it from its bounds; the smell of pomegranate oil permeates the air, sweetening everything. He wonders what Mydei would smell like, if Phainon’s scent and taste stays on him like a brand.

“My shirt,” Phainon murmurs against Mydei’s lips mindlessly, lust driving him harder than the most life-threatening battle. “My old shirt, I know your smell is all over it. Give it back.” He wants the shirt back, just so he can rub it all over, get his scent on it too so Mydei can go to town on the clothing, needy and wanting and Phainon can *help*—

Mydei freezes. “What.”

Phainon freezes, too, as Mydei peels back, eyes wide. He can't help but notice how blood-bruised Mydei's lips are now, stinging and red. "I…"

"How do you know…" Mydei doesn't finish his inquiry, but Phainon doesn't miss the tremor laced within.

Phainon can lie, can say, "Well, of course I knew you had my shirt. It went missing around our first few many spars years ago— who else would take it?" But he hadn't known, wouldn't have believed that Mydei of all people would've taken it because it's *Phainon,* who would be that wanting of him?

He tells the truth, instead, and watches as Mydei grows more and more distant, eyes almost empty once Phainon finishes. They're no longer touching, just sitting a few hand paces apart, but it feels so far. The sound of water running is loud in his ears.

"So you were cursed during our mission," Mydei says, and Phainon *hates* that desolate tone. "And you hid it from me."

Phainon shifts in the water, uncomfortable. "It wasn't causing anyone problems, I didn't see a reason to bother anyone with it."

"No, it was causing *you* problems," Mydei says, eyes flashing now. "Not to mention it was *my* mind being the problem."

"You didn't know."

"You could've told me."

"Oh, yes," Phainon says, frustration from the past two days building into a trapped wildfire. "Tell my closest friend, 'hey, can you stop thinking about me fucking you all over the place? Please and thank you oh so much, Mydeimos.'"

Mydei rears back as if Phainon had slapped him outrageously. "Maybe if you asked diplomatically, I could've acted in kind, Deliverer."

"I'm not the one with exhibitionist fantasies!" Phainon exclaims, and Mydei's eyes flare dangerously.

"They're fantasies for a reason. I wouldn't… I don't actually want them to come true."

That statement felt like an actual kick to his chest, with the way Phainon stops breathing.

"Then why did you kiss me?" Phainon asks, incensed. "Was that just a fantasy gone wrong, then?"

Mydei stares at him, before glancing away. Phainon can see how white his clenched fists are. "It was…" Mydei begins, tone anything but neutral, despite his best efforts. "It was a moment of weakness."

“A moment of weakness?” Phainon’s not understanding. “So what, those constant fantasies are just exercises of the mind for you? I’m just a convenient avatar for your scenarios? How sincere of you, Mydei.” The thought of being replaceable, of being a stand in for anyone else, or worse, being nothing to Mydei— it was beyond Phainon's frustration.

“Sincerity?” Mydei laughs something that sounds more like a choked sob, and Phainon’s terrified he’s overstepped until Mydei looks up, eyes clear and face cold. “Then why did you kiss back?”

Phainon falters. "I... it... your daydreams were... you looked like you needed... help." He wishes he could take back the clumsy words, with the way Mydei seems to stop breathing, stupefied.

"I need help?" Mydei sounds enraged. "I don't need yours or anyone's help."

"And that's the problem." Phainon wants to either cry or scream. "You're so alone, and you don't ask for help or company. Yet, you fantasize it so badly. Anyone would do, but I'm just the closest. How can I leave you alone, when you need a friend? I didn't ask to be cursed by some ancient artifact, I just wanted to understand your thoughts, even if for just a day, and maybe... maybe this is a solution."

"You think I'm having explicit fantasies of you because I lack other friends?" Mydei demands, incredulous enough that Phainon feels stupid hearing it out loud.

"You could have anyone in the world," Phainon says, and it sounds close to begging. "You don't need to fantasize closeness to this extent if you had someone."

"I can't have anyone I want," Mydei says, flatly. "That's why I can only... dream about it. Open your eyes, Deliverer."

The way he's zeroed in on Phainon, eyes blazing, makes Phainon think he should know the answer, anything that makes their situation make sense.

But it's too late for any realizations to come to light for Phainon, not with the way Mydei bares his teeth and closes off.

“Besides…” There’s something dangerous in his tone now, and Phainon tries to back away as Mydei advances, slicing through the water like a shark, dangerous and angry. Mydei stops once Phainon is trapped against the ledge, and he breathes hard once before saying, almost in a whisper, “Since you're so preoccupied with my fantasizing problem… Fantasies don’t just come from thin air. Perhaps… perhaps I don’t want my fantasies to come true. But they were inspired by something, something I think you’d remember.”

The pit of Phainon’s stomach drops as the implication of Mydei’s words start to register. “Mydei, wait…”

“You question my sincerity, and you want to fixate on my perceived exhibitionism,” Mydei says, not quite angry but very much unhappy. “But it all started years ago, around the time

when we first met. When you walked in on me with a fellow soldier after one of the bloodiest battles both our people have seen."

Unwillingly, Phainon's transported back to the time Mydei's describing, skin growing colder and colder. The familiar soldier from earlier in the day comes to mind, and he clenches his jaw.

"I… I walked away."

"What," Mydei's voice leaves no room for negotiations, "did you do before you left, Phainon? Tell me." He's watching closely now, and Phainon doesn't answer. "You stayed and you watched."

Phainon just watches back dumbly, heart loud in his ears as Mydei tears down every wall, relentless as a predator.

Mydei smiles, and it's both unfamiliar and unsettling, mirth mixed with resignation. "Most people would just leave if they stumble upon a prince of another city-state having intimacy in his own quarters," he says, musing. "That's what normal people would do. But, Phainon… you didn't. You watched as I got fucked against the wall." Phainon shudders at that, and Mydei cocks his head. "You just stood there and watched."

They're staring at each other, gazes unwavering, and Phainon's throat is dry because Mydei voiced it, made whatever happened then real, whatever lies between them more tangible.

Mydei keeps talking, an undercurrent of something in his tone. "I looked at you, and you just kept— standing there. As someone else had their way with me, and I—"

"No," Phainon's saying, voice barely louder than the running water, but he has to shut this down because it's too much. "Mydei, don't."

Mydei just looks back, eyes dark. His voice is gentle. "I just wondered, Phainon. I wondered what you were thinking. I still wonder about it, even when you never brought it up."

Phainon says nothing, and Mydei seems to take that as an answer in itself. He rises from the water, and Phainon watches as rivulets travel down that hard body like a sea nymph's caress.

"From here on out, don't touch me." The command jolts Phainon awake, and he watches in panic as Mydei begins to walk away.

"Until… until the curse ends or…" He's afraid of the answer, but Mydei just gives one last glance before leaving, his steps loud in the bath.

"What are you thinking, Phainon? Then… and now?"

Phainon says nothing, even as he returns to his own quarters alone, sitting in the dark with the windows closed, blocking the Worldbearer's light.

He says nothing, because truth be told? He hadn't really been thinking, at that point long ago.

He doesn't say that while he stayed and watched, it was Mydei who stared back, who finally came when they remained locking eyes. That he hadn't looked like he was enjoying the situation, was more tired and helping to give life-affirming touches after the losses the battle gave that day. That he seemed to go through the motions, face indifferent despite the way the walls scraped against his back— not until Phainon stayed, and watched.

He's stated that there were holes in his theory on his mind reading— and that's true for reason three. It's not that he hadn't known what Mydei sounds like in intimacy— he just can't *forget* the noise Mydei finally made when he came as Phainon watched, the soft look on his face when he finally let go. As if Phainon just looking at him was what made it good.

He doesn't say he was thinking he'd do a much better job at fucking Mydei.

Phainon says nothing. Because Mydei has always been something he's thinking of, and Phainon couldn't handle that, not so fast nor soon, when they just met. They have such heavy fates in the world— who had time for anything more than comradery and pushing the Flame-Chase Journey?

He falls into a restless sleep, dreams of gold being razed to nothing as he just watches.

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"Good morning," Phainon smiles, tired but still pushing to make his rounds.

Mydei looks back from the dining table, and then gives a nod before quietly making his excuses to leave, Phainon watching his back receding.

He sits, mind clear and so *quiet,* as the Trailblazers continue their conversation with the occasional input from the heirs. His side is colder, the seat next to him empty.

"Um…" Stelle glances over, the table clearing as everyone else finishes to start their day. "I have something for you, Phainon."

"And what might that be, partner?" Phainon smiles again, and inwardly winces at how anemic it must look if even Stelle looks discomfited.

"It's not from me, per se," she says, and then brings out a wrapped parcel. "I'm just the delivery person for Mydei. Want me to give it to you now, or drop it off at your place?"

From Mydei? Phainon's heart falls to his stomach. He can't look at it, not now. "At my place, if you don't mind. I have some plans to go over with the battalion before noon."

Plans that involve Mydei's expertise, in fact. Nervous, Phainon decides to attempt the day and regain his friend's favor before examining the delivery. They're busy, but… Phainon has to fix this, whatever this is now.

Battle plans and city fortifications are discussed, and Mydei is as professional and curt, eyes sharp yet thoughtful as he helps map out the information. He talks and listens to Phainon, but doesn't laugh quietly or react to Phainon's light teasing, merely blinking back slow.

They disband the meeting around lunchtime, and his hopes rise when Mydei places his favorite meal and snack down at his usual spot. Said hopes are dashed when Mydei makes his leave, stating Kokopo III needed his assistance. What kind of assistance does a dromas need when the caretakers are right there?! Mydei's never skipped lunch with Phainon, before.

But he's also never had his mind read before in such explicit fashion.

Looking at the chimera cookies grinning back from their plate, Phainon has to confront the fact that Mydei's sincerity has always been a tangible and heartfelt thing in their harsh world.

And the more their time together goes on, the more Phainon's heart sinks.

"Mydei," he says, when he manages to corner the man alone. He tries not to take it personally at how stiff Mydei looks, looking at him like a stranger. "Would you… would you want to spar, later?" Not what he wanted to say— but he doesn't know exactly what to say, is the problem. All he knows now is that he wants Mydei to say yes.

Please say yes.

Mydei does no such thing, just looks at Phainon with those impassive, flame eyes. "I don't think that's a good idea."

"I'm sorry for everything," spills from Phainon's lips, and he can't even feel defensive, not when silence has brought him to the gallows this far. "I just… I don't want us to…"

A sigh, but Mydei's eyes soften. He makes as if to reach out, to maybe give Phainon a calming pat, but freezes and brings his hand back. Phainon wants to drag that hand back, and never let go. "It's not your fault, you don't have to be sorry. I just… was not lying."

"About?"

Mydei's silent. "My moment of weakness," is all he finally says. "I can't let it happen again. There are too many responsibilities for us both to be distracted. I'll be alright, no need to worry."

Phainon's chest is going to cave in at this rate, with the amount of kicks its been getting. "We… can't go back?" Back to what? Before the compass? Before their time together, all these years and spars and baths? Before they met?

"Yes," Mydei says. "I apologize… for my indiscreet thoughts. It gave you much trouble. I know you care and... you just wanted to help me while letting me keep my dignity. I understand that now."

"I don't mind the trouble, you know that," Phainon shakes his head. "I'd take fifty more of trouble, at this rate." *Just don't go, not like this.*

Mydei just regards him, the air charged between them. Then he smiles, something fragile in the curve of his lips. "I... have never had a friend like you. That's why it's better this way. You

have your duties, I have mine. The Flame-Chase Journey marches on, Deliverer. I wish you eternal victory."

He ducks around Phainon, and the urge to touch and hold on, to be able to *see* what Mydei is really thinking is so strong. If Mydei is thinking of kissing him again, or fantasizing Phainon's touch, or… Phainon's more afraid of seeing nothing. He lets Mydei go.

Returning back home, he rushes to the parcel Stelle delivered, ripping apart the wrapping and then stumbling back at the contents: his old shirt, newly washed and mended.

He thumbs at where the tear used to be, recognizing Mydei's utilitarian stitching anywhere, from battlefield wounds to fraying holes in clothes. The shirt barely smells of Mydei anymore, having gone through the communal laundry. Only a hint of sweetness remains. Without thinking, Phainon claws at the stitching, reintroducing the old tear to the shirt to try to resemble what it was, all those years ago; he's left in frayed tatters and stray strings, instead.

His eyes land on his shelf, and there the cursed compass lies— the start of this. In a fit of sudden, agonized rage, he grabs it and throws it hard at the wall, uncaring if it used to be a vessel for a portion of Janus' powers, and watches it break in pieces from impact.

Nothing changes.

Finally, Phainon begins to laugh, but there's no mirth.

They really can't go back now, can they?

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"I need you two to help one of the coastal city-states evacuate," Aglaea says, eyes cool as watches Phainon and Mydei scan their mission reports. "The other heirs are preoccupied with the recent attacks, but I know you both are able to complete this mission quickly and efficiently."

"Coastal city-state?" Phainon scans the map to find the location. "Is it really a city, even?"

"Not your typical one," Aglaea admits. "Not even a man-made one. More of… floating structures, in the waves. There's been missives requesting aid from abyssal sea sirens, but I fear their way of life will come to an end soon, at this rate."

"Just us?" Mydei asks, the first thing he's voiced during their meeting, and Phainon's ears perk.

Aglaea shakes her head. "The Trailblazer— Dan Heng— has volunteered for the task as well, considering his proficiency with water and desire to learn from Amphoreus."

Phainon can't help the spike of ire at Mydei's visible relief at the news. What— is Phainon too unbearable to be around now that some stranger from the sky is preferable?

But then he remembers the lost look in Mydei's eyes when Phainon spilled the truth, and he deflates, watching Mydei make his leave to relay the update to Dan Heng.

"Is there… no one else? To take on this mission?" Phainon asks, haltingly. "The Trailblazer, well, they're rather new to our duties, after all."

Aglaea is silent, regarding Phainon with her millennium-old eyes, and he shifts, uncomfortable before her gaze but not wanting to disappoint.

"There once was a demigod," Aglaea begins, and he moves close to her side, to listen, "who was capable of commanding the seas. She is no longer with us."

"The one who conquered Phagousa's Coreflame," Phainon surmises, and Aglaea tips her head in acknowledgment.

"A sea siren who only wanted to play her melodies and feast, but participated in the Flame-Chase, instead," Aglaea says, and there's a quality in her voice that makes Phainon feel the deepest grief. "She would've been the best qualified for your mission; you would have been guaranteed complete safety."

The way Aglaea spoke of this lost demigod had Phainon really re-evaluate his mentor, at the way the years suddenly seem to weigh on her as she stares out in the far distance, where the far-off shores of Styxia lie.

"Is the Flame-Chase truly all there is, for us?" Phainon asks, barely able to withstand the amount of love lost for Aglaea, for everyone involved with fate. "Nothing else but a duty to bear suffering for the world?"

Aglaea regards him, and he feels like that lost young man before her again, alone and grieving for a dead world that can never return. "Do you wish to leave the Chase, Phainon?"

"No, I can't. I won't."

"But would you, given a miraculous chance?"

He thinks about it, thinks about the sacrifices and suffering the other heirs and people have experienced. He thinks of Mydei and his immortality, of never-ending rest but constant chosen battles for a man who desired gentler times.

"No. I wouldn't change anything. I can bear the pain."

"Then your fate to the Chase is sealed. You belong to it." Aglaea's smile is of resigned sadness. She reaches out, carding her fine hand through his hair, and he leans into the touch; wetness builds behind his eyes at her affection, an ever present thing since his arrival, despite the people's regard towards her waning humanity. "However… just because the Chase is an ending, does not mean it's your complete journey. You still have time, Phainon."

She sees through him and his own worries. He's not sure if he does have time, as she so believes in him. But… "If you could do it again, would you choose to be with the ocean demigod?"

At that, Aglaea laughs. “No. I would want to, but it wouldn’t have been possible. She had her own Imperator to follow, after all.”

Their conversation sticks with him, even as he departs on the mission. He thinks about their all-consuming duty to a dying world, about Aglaea’s enduring grief, about Tribbie’s conjectures about Janus’ powers and the pathways and traps of destiny. He looks at Mydei’s silhouette stark against the light as they sail, and thinks about time.

Does he have time?

Seeing Dan Heng lean next to Mydei on the small ship, elbows touching even, as they converse— something stifling is in Phainon’s chest, and he grits his teeth to manage the ropes.

He thinks about Aglaea, how her affections weren’t enough to keep a sea siren from following fire.

What if he doesn’t have time, but Mydei does?

Time to live, to… find someone Mydei dreams of. Him wanting it and it coming true.

Phainon accidentally tears through the rope, prompting protest from the sailor close by, and he apologizes, even as he thinks, ‘I’ll be happy for him once he finds his dream.’

The stifling feeling doesn’t dissipate.

“You seem rather tense,” Dan Heng says, and Phainon immediately swivels around to see the man place a light hand on Mydei’s forearm. “Seasick? I could possibly try to ease the waters, however unfamiliar they may be.”

“It’s fine,” Mydei says, and he doesn’t shrug off the touch. “I spent the first few years of life underwater, after all.”

The Sea of Souls, where Mydei fought and died and came back to life every time, Phainon remembers. Suddenly, he wants to demand Dan Heng to work his magic and calm the waters, just so Mydei can be at ease.

“I can’t imagine that being a peaceful time,” Dan Heng notes diplomatically.

“No,” Mydei laughs, the sound low. He seems calmer. “But I was found and brought to the surface. And that’s what counts in the end.”

They leave the range of Kephale’s light, and night falls, the sky turning dark. Phainon deigns to take first watch for the night, and observes as Dan Heng and Mydei take their respective spots on the deck to sleep, sitting upright. All is quiet for a few hours, until a huff of breath catches Phainon’s attention and he turns to track the sound to Mydei’s corner.

The man, on the surface, seems calm, sleeping almost like the dead if Phainon hadn’t seen his chest rise and fall imperceptibly. But just as he knows how Mydei breathes when alive and awake, he knows how the man sleeps and dies— and the hitches in his breath has Phainon flit

over, body moving on its own just to reach out and wake Mydei from what he knows are nightmares.

He barely has time to remember Mydei's warning to not touch— but it's too late as Phainon's hand clasps onto Mydei's shoulder.

The sensation of drowning, and the sounds of muffled cries underwater are horrifying; he gags, feeling phantom water enter his lungs with no way out. Mydei in this dream struggles, fighting against unseen monsters and foes as he lives and dies in the murky dark.

It breaks Phainon's heart, the pain vivid enough for him to see past the dream to whisper, *"Mydeimos."*

Immediately, dream Mydei stops, and the almost overpowering feelings of *calm* and *safety* permeates, letting Phainon sigh in relief. Then, he hears his own voice in the dream say Mydei's name, and real Mydei wakes up.

Flame-tinged eyes regard him, and Mydei seems to be unaware of his own waking state, as he just stares at Phainon before smiling. The feelings flowing through the man are strong as Mydei thinks, clear in Phainon's brain, *"I don't want to wake from this dream,"* with so much fondness and affection, it crushes any sense Phainon has at the truth before him.

His own gasp is loud, and it seems to truly wake Mydei when the man blinks and then shoves Phainon away, clear shock and almost animal-like panic on his face.

"You…" Mydei trails off, tense in restrained violence, and Phainon is already raising his hands in surrender.

"You were having a nightmare," Phaion says, biting his lip. "I'm sorry, I know… I know you said not to touch you."

Mydei watches him, eyes cooler now before he gives a curt nod and says he'll take the next watch. Phainon is forced to settle in the spot Mydei had occupied, looking at the way Mydei once again leans against the edge of the ship, as he realizes to himself: "I am his dream."

Open your eyes, Deliverer.

Feeling like a massive, blind idiot is an understatement, as Phainon closes his eyes to try to sleep as per Mydei's gruff instruction.

But he can't, not really, not when he's received confirmation on the truth.

A moment of weakness, indeed. Phainon wants to bash his head into a rock. Stupid, stupid, *stupid.*

Mydei doesn't like baths, but looking at Phainon calms his nerves, makes being near water easier.

Mydei keeps an old shirt because it's all he can have, and not the person it belongs to.

Mydei fantasizes but doesn't want any of it to come true, because it's just not real and he's always, always been a realist.

Phainon never said anything, so Mydei only dreams.

He's an idiot, but so is Mydei, for not taking Phainon's silence as an answer in itself back then: petty, deep jealousy that stayed his tongue, to choose a close friendship instead of asking for more out of a sense of losing already.

He wants to laugh, and he wants to cry, because the greatest of joys blooming in Phainon's heart are being thrashed heartily by his own misconceptions pushing them this far.

What time does he have now, to love Mydeimos in his entirety?

They dock on a coast a day later and encounter the mentioned city-state, truly a structure of floating boats and bridges in the ocean. Their time is filled up, directing people to take the inland routes to Okhema as they load the elderly, sick, and children onto the ship they came in, to make the journey faster. It's not until day three that things become dire, the reports of abyssal sea creatures in the area being true.

Phainon's slicing through several of them for menacing some remaining children before he hears a crashing noise; looking up, he sees a massive creature, stained and corrupted by the black tide, rising from the depths like fabled sea monsters from the Sea of Souls.

Cursing, he scoops a wayward child, and bounds with the rest, settling the crowd on the beach before turning back to the waters— just to see Dan Heng get smashed into a wooden house, people screaming as the impact begins to sink the floor they're standing on.

"Dan Heng!" He yells, alarmed out of his mind. Glancing over to the nearby structure, he sees another group of people on, panic clear on their faces as the colossal sea creature slices through the water towards them.

Before he can choose which group to save, a golden flash lunges, and Phainon watches as Mydei violently tears a limb from the monster, face wild.

"Go," Mydei snarls, eyes blazing before he turns to fight once again, swift feet dancing over the light wood as his body moves, a weapon of war.

The urge to aid Mydei, to fight by his side and watch his back is strong, but Phainon has to do what needs to be done. Gritting his teeth, he wades out into the water, and begins to evacuate one group as Dan Heng emerges again to help the other. There are still a number of people left to bring to shore before he hears a sharp intake of breath from Dan Heng, and looks out again to see Mydei's form disappear beneath the waves, struggle visible even from their distance.

"I can get him," Dan Heng says, setting his charge down as he readies to enter the waves. "Can you take it from here, Phainon?"

‘No, *you* stay here,’ Phainon wants to immaturely demand, wanting so badly to be the one to go after his friend— but Mydei’s nightmare about fighting and drowning in the water has him relent, and nod his acquiescence. Phainon has to want more than Mydei is given.

Dan Heng dives into the water to hunt, and Phainon keeps his attention preoccupied with wrangling the leftover stragglers. He doesn’t know how long time flows by, only the sense of barely restrained terror coursing through his veins as he struggles to uphold his end of the work.

Finally, the sound of water breaking catches his focus, and Phainon turns to see Dan Heng skidding along the surface and hitting beach, rising again as Mydei follows out of the water, teeth bared and face bloody. Phainon’s heart stops in his chest at the sight of golden, bloody tears streaking down Mydei’s face; a large jagged slash bisects his eyes, blinding him, as numerous other blows and stab wounds litter his body, flesh clearly attempting to knit back to hold the man together. Mydei makes no audible human noise, just choking, watery sounds that raises the hair on Phainon’s neck as he stumbles, limbs moving to fight some unknown enemy in his haze, even when falling apart.

“There’s water in his lungs,” he hears Dan Heng says, and the Trailblazer tries to circle around, usually impassive face stiff with concern and a dash of fear. “I can try to get it out to stop the drowning— but he can’t seem to hear me, despite the enemy being dead.” There’s red blood trickling at the corner of his mouth, no doubt from one of Mydei’s blows in his blinded frenzy.

Mydei doesn’t like the water, barely able to stand baths the first time he arrived in Okhema.

Phainon knows now that he can calm him, can give him that sense of ease again to bear the water.

He rushes forward in a splash and catches Mydei’s blow firmly, the clang of sharp gauntlet against his own blade jarring, even with all of his strength. “Mydei,” he calls, but Mydei can’t hear nor see him, not yet; all he sees in front of him and in Mydei’s mind is blindingly cold fear and the desire to fight to live. So they skirmish, a dance as familiar to Phainon’s own the day they met, as he gives time for Mydei’s body to heal and regenerate. “Mydeimos,” he says, every other breath, willing the other man to come back to him.

Sharp claws manages to latch onto neck and tearing his choker, dragging him, and Phainon hisses at the pain but goes with it. The momentum gives him an advantage to kick out Mydei’s feet, the two rolling into the water and sand before Mydei gets pinned, water surging around them.

“Mydei,” Phainon croaks, feeling blood well from the wound onto the side of neck; he leans closer, feeling more than seeing Mydei’s struggles in mind and body calm as Phainon’s voice breaks through. He nuzzles Mydei’s face with his own, smearing blood but making sure Mydei recognizes him. “It’s Phainon. It’s me.”

A few moments pass, and finally, Mydei’s new eyes look upon him, wide and so gold. “It’s you,” he whispers through water, and Phainon’s heart finally settles.

There are barely thoughts in Mydei's mind, only feelings of residual distress, and Phainon holds him close, knowing he's providing some relief as Dan Heng creeps closer to work his abilities. Water is slowly pulled out of Mydei's chest, and the man finally inhales, taking in air shakily once the last of it leaves him.

"I'm sorry," Mydei rasps, regret deep in his tone as he takes in Dan Heng's battered state.

The Trailblazer good-naturedly shrugs. "I'm glad you're alright now," is all he says, smiling a bit at Mydei until the latter nods back in thanks.

Then Mydei freezes, and Phainon knows he's finally realized their position, cradled securely in Phainon's arms; the unease and shame emanating from the man is strong, even as the desire for Phainon to *keep touching* is stronger. Mydei pulls away anyway, eyes dragging over Phainon's neck, golden blood mixed with Mydei's own.

"I'm alright," Phainon reassures him, voice thick. "We're okay."

Mydei just looks at him as if he's lying, but slowly nods. "My apologies for your wound," he says. He turns away and closes his eyes, holding himself together even as all of Phainon wants to hold him. "It won't happen again."

But the thing is, Phainon keeps thinking, as they put themselves back together to complete their mission— he wants it to happen again.

Wants to hold Mydei again. Wants Mydei to leave his marks on Phainon's body in any way, again. Wants Mydei to not be alone, to feel free and laugh again.

Wants to accompany him, to be the one to give Mydei what he wants and needs.

Wants to take from him in turn, all of Mydei's sounds and pleasure and pain his own.

Phainon watches Mydei as they journey back to Okhema, and thinks of making time.

***

He knows Mydei has been avoiding the baths, presence scarce. He doesn't blame him, as his nightmares now consist of Mydei drowning, the watery struggles and choking loud in Phainon's ears when he wakes.

But he knows Mydei has tried to fight the memory, venturing close to the baths and watching, before turning away again to bathe with a bucket of water and towels in his own quarters.

He sees glimpses of that shaking determination, every time he brushes by Mydei in their day to day.

Mydei gives him long looks at their brushes— not outright touches, but a touch nonetheless — and says nothing; Phainon doesn't push it.

Tonight, he will.

Phainon gets ready, watching the late hour past by. The compass, pieces gently placed on his shelf, seem to peer back at him.

He no longer feels agony or wretched when looking at the item, because now, he thinks he understands Tribbie's caution and Aglaea's contemplation.

What you want may not be what you need.

He wanted to get a glimpse of Mydei's mind, to have any insight on what the man thought, what his desires were. Phainon was burnt, instead, but now, he thinks it's what he needed, to be confronted by his own truths and wants— no more justifications or excuses.

He wants to get what he needs.

"Mydeimos," Phainon greets, once Mydei opened the door to his knocks. His heart is loud in his ears, even as he says, "Let's go take a bath."

There are dark circles under Mydei's eyes, but it doesn't detract from how unimpressed he looks; the visage has Phainon smile, feeling more hopeful in weeks. "…And what if I reject your request," Mydei says, and Phainon chuckles.

"Then I'll keep trying, just like old times." He smiles winningly, playing on Mydei's soft nature. "Come on. I'll show a good spot, just for you."

He can see the visible struggling warring behind Mydei's eyes, but— now that his own eyes are open, he can *see*— Mydei relents, and goes with Phainon's way in the end, as always.

Phainon trails through Marmoreal Palace, hearing Mydei behind him, as he leads him to a secluded area where the water is shallow enough to be mostly floor, with a gentle waterfall in place.

"This is more a shower than a bath," Mydei observes, and Phainon knows he's still nervous, but they'll get there.

"It's in the bathing area connected to the other baths, ergo, a bath," Phainon counters, hearing Mydei snort. He watches as Mydei sets his bathing supplies down, getting ready to strip.

"…You can leave now," Mydei says, fingers rubbing at the edge of his robe. "I don't need your help. Or an audience."

Phainon doesn't want to be an audience. "No," is what he says, and he starts stripping, too, taking in Mydei's wide glance. "I asked to take a bath with you, and I will." Walking over to the ledge, right by the waterfall, he gestures, waiting.

Mydei's eyes go from Phainon to the soaps in his hand, and a flush grows on his face, a mixture of anger and embarrassment clear. "I'm not a child. And I said… I said there would be no more touching. Especially with that curse on you."

"I want to touch you, though." He wonders why he's never told the truth from the beginning, not if it makes Mydei crumble so easily. "Let me?"

“Let you? That rule was for your own good and well-being. Unless you think to help me out of a sense of duty, then forget it.”

“I think I’m more wanting to help myself, at this point,” Phainon says honestly. “I’m sorry about that, Mydei, but I really want you to sit here.”

A few moments pass, and then Mydei finally does, baring that conspicuous body to Phainon’s greedy eyes, and slowly walking over. He trembles once, a small thing, before sitting, still as stone once Phainon starts to gently run water through his hair, wetting it.

It’s calming, washing Mydei’s hair. Phainon lathers it carefully, finally feeling settled himself since their coastal mission, now that he has Mydei in his grasp and can take care of him. He digs his fingers into Mydei’s scalp and massages, feeling phantom surprise at the pleasure emanate from the man, even as Mydei tries his best to silence any and all thoughts.

Phainon wants to change that.

The soap is rinsed away, and before Mydei can react, Phainon’s sliding his hands along Mydei’s neck, shoulders, chest, rubbing and rinsing. Mydei’s skin is burning, and his eyes are dark, even as he seems blindsided by Phainon’s closeness; a stray thought unwillingly dashes across his mind, but Phainon sees it— a daydream of him leaning down to kiss Mydei, to hold him close.

So he does.

“What—“ Mydei gasps, even as imaginary him moans, and Phainon presses, nearly making the both of them slip as he kisses hard, licking away any real protest and biting back any angry retorts. Both daydream and reality starts to mesh together, and Phainon revels in it, revels in obliterating a fantasy for something real and theirs. Tangling a harsh hand in Mydei’s hair, Phainon jerks his head back, a loud moan actually escaping Mydei’s mouth as Phainon starts to kiss the arch of his neck, the hollow of his pretty throat, leaving his own marks behind to mirror the one still healing on himself. He’s shoved back, but barely, just his head as Mydei looks at him, flush bright and expression incredulous.

“Has the curse made you lose whatever mind you had left?” Mydei asks, and Phainon laughs; the sound seems to make Mydei angrier because he jerks hard at Phainon’s hair, flinching back at the resulting moan for his troubles. “You are— you… if you’re doing this just because of the curse—“

“The curse is a blessing, actually,” Phainon says, and Mydei falls silent. Thumbing at Mydei’s lips, Phainon continues on, a mixture of grief at time lost and joy of being able to have something now at war with each other. “I… apologize for the invasion of privacy. I know you didn’t want to reveal anything, to not cause trouble. You’ve always been strong, Mydei, strong enough for the both of us.” He touches his forehead to Mydei’s, feeling sweet breath over his own lips, and closes his eyes. “But I’m not. I’m weak, and I’ve wanted you from the beginning. I was jealous and would rather make excuses than pursue what I really wanted, because… what if you didn’t want me back?”

“You…” Mydei shakes, hands clenched. “What are you saying?” He sounds like he doesn’t want to hope, the feeling of wanting to run strong in his mind as Phainon sees.

Unfortunately, Phainon’s done letting him run, and traps him hard against the ledge, almost bruising. “I’m saying that I’m sorry,” Phainon tells him, keeping eye contact as he slides low to Mydei’s thighs. He grins as Mydei’s cock twitches, finally rising, even as the man tries to close his legs; he bullies them apart, wanting and wanting and hoping Mydei will give. “I’m sorry it took seeing your mind to realize my own courage. It shouldn’t have gone that far— but I don’t regret it. I don’t regret wanting you all this time and finally doing something about it.” He kisses Mydei’s stomach, moving over that hard plane until he sinks his teeth in the soft portion, delighting in the way the muscles jump. “I want to blow your fantasies apart, and I want your affections, and I especially want to fuck you.”

“There are— this is a public bath,” Mydei hisses, the only argument he’s able to muster, much to Phainon’s satisfaction. “I thought you detested exhibitionism.”

“I do,” Phainon answers simply. “I don’t like people watching you, but I hate being the voyeur more. If they can hear you…” He digs his fingers in hard hips, relishing the low moan that comes out of Mydei’s throat. “Well, then they’ll know that I’m the one that can give it to you good.”

He jerks Mydei forward, slinging strong thighs over his shoulders as Mydei nearly falls and has to catch himself on the ledge, abs tensing. Giving no chance for Mydei to protest or to second-guess their arrangement, Phainon shoves forward, swallowing and licking his way to victory at Mydei’s near yell.

“Go on,” Phainon tells him, licking his way down Mydei’s shaft and sucking on the head. He leans back, just to spit in his hand and now bullying fingers into Mydei’s hole, the spit barely gliding a ways; that doesn’t seem to stop the fantasies of Mydei grinding back on it filthily, and Phainon tilts his body, making him work on his fingers even as he makes Mydei’s dreams come true. “Go on, scream. Let all of the city know who’s making the prince of Castrum Kremnos feel so good.”

“You’re insane,” Mydei says, trying to sound reserved but coming off like a slut instead, and Phainon sucks harder, giving him a reward with the way Mydei tosses his pretty head back, biting back a broken sound.

“No more fantasies,” Phainon says, voice a rasp as he pulls back and gets up, jerking Mydei along with him. The waterfall hits their skin as he has Mydei against the wall, hands clenching like cute paws in front of him as Phainon plasters against him from behind. He bites all over, leaving stinging marks healing in his wake, even as he shoves two fingers back into Mydei, giving the man something to squeeze on. “I can give you what you want, so you don’t need to imagine anymore, Mydei. You just have to tell me.”

“More,” Mydei says, through his panting; he reaches an arm back, bringing Phainon forward into a biting kiss. “I want more, Deliverer.”

There are probably people around, the hour still early enough for the occasional late-night bather; Phainon doesn’t care, not with the way he pulls back just to close Mydei’s legs

together, and then proceeding to shove his cock into that tight space. He fucks those thighs roughly, the occasional friction against Mydei's own length a nice, nice treat, especially with the way Mydei seems to be losing his mind, growing wilder in his lust.

A hard rub against Mydei's balls, and Mydei makes an aborted whimper as he comes, the sound ringing in Phainon's brain. He pulls back and starts jerking roughly, holding Mydei down as he finally puts the tip of his cock to Mydei's hole— not entering, despite the delicious heat— and comes, white staining inside and out.

They both sag, and Phainon sloppily kisses Mydei's back, wanting to stay close.

"What," Mydei finally says, and Phainon looks up to see his musing face. "You didn't want to be inside me?"

"Spoiled prince," Phainon teases, laughing a little at the way Mydei frowns (pouts) and shoves back. "Of course I do. But I have my own fantasies, too, you know."

"Is that so."

"Yes. We have to be in my room for that part, though. Don't wash up." Phainon warns, draping their robes loosely over themselves. Mydei gives him a wry look.

"Then what was the point of going to the baths?"

Phainon just laughs again and kisses him deep, feeling Mydei sigh as he melts; the sheer contentment and surprised joy in Mydei's mind, though, is what humbles Phainon the most.

Heat steadily builds in him again as they rush back to Phainon's quarters; the knowledge that his come is seeping out of Mydei behind the robe— he has to adjust himself, mouth salivating.

They're barely through the door before Phainon's pushing Mydei to the bed, stripping him of the robes and touching him all over. Come stains the insides of Mydei's thighs in a dripping mess, and the desire to drop down and taste is almost too strong to bear. He shoves Mydei on soft sheets instead, letting the man sit up on his elbows to see what Phainon is doing.

A conflicted expression crosses Mydei's face in a hot blush, the moment he sees Phainon take out the old, linen shirt. "You…" He struggles to find the words. "I…"

Phainon grins, almost wolfish as he advances. "Put it on, Mydei."

"You weren't supposed to see," Mydei says, angry and lustful in equal measure. "Are you making fun?"

"Making fun? Mydei, you masturbating with my shirt woke many, many things in me. I should ask you to take responsibility, actually, with the way I can't seem to want anything less."

Mydei takes hold of the shirt and slowly slips it on, shocked nearly silent by Phainon's statement. "And… what do you want me to do with this?"

Phainon trails a hand over Mydei's foot, before latching onto his ankle and jerking him hard, making Mydei lose balance. "I want you to do the same thing you were doing that day, after the baths," Phainon says, pleasantly. He crawls close, just to give another kiss. "I want yours and mine's smell over this shirt, lingering in the air, the two scents mixed as you touch yourself and I touch you. Will you do that for me?"

'This incorrigible pervert,' Phainon hears Mydei think, but the cock hardening against his thigh seems to be answer enough.

"Pervert this and pervert that— consider this petty revenge to half the things you've subjected my mind to, Mydei," Phainon tells him, fingers dancing down to his hole once again as Mydei starts to stroke himself. He pushes two— then four— fingers in, feeling the sloppy mess he's left behind and Mydei twitches, insides so hot. "The insanity I've experienced in one morning and not being able to truly do anything about it. I'm only giving back in kind."

"Your fault for getting cursed," Mydei reminds him in a breathy moan, fucking into his fist even as he pushes back onto Phainon's fingers. "That'll teach you."

"Yes," Phainon says, endeared and in love. "Teach me to give you everything."

He sinks his teeth onto Mydei's nipple, latching on hard and licking all over as he kneads the flesh with a mean hand; at that, Mydei tenses and comes suddenly, wetness staining his stomach and shirt, a stuttering groan leaving his throat. Intent, Phainon sits up just to rub the fluids every where, his own come-stained hand mixing with Mydei's and slathering all over that body. The musky scent in the air has him groan, too, deep in his throat, senses alight.

Mydei pants, looking down and seeing Phainon's hardness. "Wait, you didn't…" He struggles a little, and Phainon just wants to eat him alive. "Give me a few minutes."

Phainon just strokes a hand over Mydei's thigh before slinging it over his shoulder, hearing Mydei hiss at the stretch. He drags his cock close to that hot and messy hole, and looks straight into Mydei's eyes, saying with a sweet smile, "Don't worry, Mydeimos. You don't need to be hard to still be fucked." He pushes in, warmth enveloping him, still tight from Mydei's pleasure prior.

"You *hks*—" Mydei curses, trying to hide what Phainon senses to be tears into the bedding. His face is dragged forward instead, and he whines as Phainon tests his flexibility, just to bend to kiss and kiss.

"Curse me all you want," Phainon pants, as he leans back to start snapping his hips relentlessly, the sound of their flesh slapping against each other, loud and sharp. "You're not getting rid of me that easily."

"I don't want to get rid of you," Mydei says, clenching his teeth against the sharp pleasure-pain, cock bouncing up and down and starting to harden again from Phainon's thrusts. "I just want you."

Phainon's eyes nearly water at that, heart clenching even as he reaches his peak. He pulls out and sets down Mydei's thigh, ignoring his half-hearted protests just to take Mydei in hand and to fill him back up again, fucking him the way they both want and need.

"I want you, and I don't want you to want anyone else," Phainon says through his struggling breath, raining as many kisses over Mydei's face as he's able, as if trying to provide payment for Mydei's attention. "I don't want to share you with anyone, not with your soldiers, other people, or even *me."*

"Phainon." Mydei kisses back hard, and digs a hand into the meat of Phainon's ass, stopping his movements and keeping him in deep as he forces them both over the edge, hot ass milking Phainon for all he's worth. He pants in the aftermath, face too fond in wonderment. "There was only just you."

It's barely hours later when Phainon wakes, hand already reaching out to the empty, still warm spot on the bed.

"Really, Deliverer," he hears Mydei say, and Phainon is grinning at the unimpressed tone as he turns and open his eyes, not sure what ire he's wrought from his prince today but eager to face it.

Mydei's on the edge of the bed, bare now as he holds up the linen shirt. Phainon appraises approvingly of the stains still on it, before he zeros in at the new addition: his tear from weeks before now mended, remade by Mydei's deft hands. This time, red thread laces at the site, and he reaches out to rub it, marveling.

"I recall giving this back to you whole," Mydei says, rather cool. That coolness gets obliterated by Phainon taking his hand and moving to kiss every finger. "Don't distract me now, you scoundrel."

"I'm not distracting you, I'm thanking you," Phainon hums, sitting up to properly press his lips to that peerless face. His dick twitches at the growing flush on Mydei's skin, insatiable. "I didn't know how to go back, when I made that tear."

"Hmph," Mydei says, but he leans into welcoming arms. "Good thing we're moving forward, instead." He looks at Phainon. "Know what I'm thinking?"

He no longer can hear Mydei's thoughts, but staring at the gentle expression on Mydei's face, he thinks he's never seen more clearly with his eyes wide open.

"I think I can just ask you," he says, as he touches the shirt again, thumbing over where Mydei's heartfelt sincerity is woven in.

End Notes

phaidei worrying about exhibitionism and they're right. it was me, i was the voyeur in the baths 😌

kudos and reviews are alwayyyyssss appreciateddd~

Edit: THANK YOU COSUMOSU FOR THE BEAUTIFUL ART, AAHHHHHH, I'M LITERALLY SCREAMING IN JOY 😭🙏❤️ please everyone, check their art and profile out PLEASEEEE

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!